

Policies and problems

Supply depots were established near railroads and steamship wharves. The North had little trouble gathering supplies from its farmlands and industries and depositing them in the depots. In contrast, the South, trammelled by the North's naval blockade and its own inefficiencies, faced greater difficulties. In the middle of the war, the Confederate Army of Tennessee found itself particularly short of supplies. The logistics policy meant that it was deprived of its natural resource base in Tennessee. Local foodstuffs were gathered and diverted instead to the Confederate depot in Atlanta, from where they were shipped by train to Petersburg to feed Lee's Army of Northern Virginia.

By 1864, the Union campaigns against the railroad hubs at Petersburg and Atlanta faced contrasting logistical issues. At Petersburg, where General Ulysses S. Grant had the James River at his back, his supply base was close to his headquarters. He had established a depot at City Point, where mountains of war material was piled amidst railroads, wharves, hospitals, repair shops, blacksmith forges, and even bakeries making 100,000 loaves daily. Ten miles (16km) away, General Robert E. Lee fought to protect the last of the Petersburg railroads still bringing in supplies from the Confederacy's rapidly shrinking resource base in southern Virginia and North Carolina.

Railroad to Atlanta

At Atlanta, Union general William T. Sherman was also dependent on a single lifeline. Supplies had to be brought over a single-track railroad that snaked hundreds of miles through the hills of Georgia to supply bases in Tennessee. To protect the route, he garrisoned every mile of it and then stockpiled depots along the way. Without the railroad, he said, his four-month campaign would have required "36,800 wagons."